Kate Bernola

Design (UX) | Knowledge management | Change management | AI adoption

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I build practices that didn't exist, get them adopted across organizations, and leave teams permanently more capable than I found them.

SKILLS

People management
Change management
Knowledge management
Governance
Team building
Cross-functional leadership
Executive communication
Process design
Design leadership
AI adoption

AWARDS

Brandon Hall gold
2022, Paychex Voice Assist
Best advance in AI for business impact

Brandon Hall bronze
2022, Retention Insights
Best advance in HR predictive analytics

Silver Stevie
2021, PPP Loan Forgiveness Estimator

My work contributed to these industry awards, plus 27 others.

EXPERIENCE

Paychex — 2019 – 2026

UX Design Manager, Product Design and Head of Multimedia — 2024 – 2026

LEADING TEAMS

- Managed a team of 13 designers and 2 researchers across 4 product areas: Tax, Payments, the accountant platform and its design system, and multimedia.
- Built customer journeys for tax registration and payments. Exposed major pain points. Won funding to fix them, standing up a new portfolio with a dozen dev teams.
- Restructured the group to support Paycor, a newly acquired HCM platform, without adding headcount, redefining roles and the coverage model rather than simply growing the org.
- Inherited a multimedia team spending half its time on videos that mirrored Help Center articles. Found 95% would never justify the cost. Stopped the work, moved the team to a shared service, and cut over $150K in overhead.

GOVERNANCE

- Moved in-app marketing from prohibited to permitted. Founded a governance board to ensure oversight from support, marketing, and Product. Set guardrails and proposed alternatives to asks that put client relationships at risk.
- As UX representative on the ROI committee, reviewed proposed IT investments and assigned designers to early planning, preventing delays of 2 to 6 weeks.
- Designed a new Help Center taxonomy, mapping 1,500+ articles to 15 topics and directly improving our AI chatbot's answers.
- Led the transition of Paychex Flex customer-facing knowledge to an acquired company's knowledge management team. Aligned knowledge ownership, governance, and upkeep between a highly governed enterprise and a small, fast-moving org.

BUSINESS RESULTS

- Built a Claude agent to find recurring problems in call logs. Compressed 6 weeks of discovery into 8 days, and won a seat in early roadmap planning.
- Convinced an exec to test telling admins we advertised paid benefits to employees, a fact hidden for fear they'd restrict access to the offer. Under 2% opted out; instead, admins promoted the offers, and employee visits rose 6.8x. This became the standard.
- Led a marketing campaign for a partner offering that generated $7M in revenue. Achieved 1.9x growth year-over-year. Exceeded revenue goal by 22%.
- Flagged the risk when a cross-sell campaign threatened the app's navigation. Designed alternatives, proved 2x click-through with an A/B test, and set exposure limits. Campaign generated 148 wins and $500K in recurring revenue.

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TOOLS

PROJECT MANAGEMENT
Jira, Confluence, Trello, Visio

ANALYTICS
Heap, Pendo, Google Analytics

AI ASSISTANTS
Claude, ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, LibreChat

CONTENT MANAGEMENT
SharePoint, Drupal, WordPress

DESIGN
Figma, Figma Make, Miro, ZeroHeight

EDUCATION

University of Notre Dame
BBA, Marketing & Psychology
Magna cum laude, 3.7 GPA
Lean Six Sigma Green Belt, obtained at Xerox

EXPERIENCE continued

UX Design Manager, Head of Content Design — 2021 – 2024

PRACTICE BUILDING

- Transformed a knowledge management team into a content design practice, growing it from 1 to 12 and supporting 40+ product designers across 100+ dev teams.
- Hired 11 people and personally trained 9 with no prior content design experience, including 2 internal hires. Achieved 75% promotion rate and 92% retention. Details
- After 2.5 years, decentralized the content design team from a shared service to an embedded model. Positioned a senior content designer to lead the team.

GOVERNANCE

- Built a change management framework from research, competitive analysis, and user studies. Helped teams separate risk mitigation from feature awareness with one question: can the user still do the task the way they did before?
- Owned governance for Paychex customer-facing knowledge base: what belongs in it, who owns and approves it, how it sounds, and a six-month review cadence that retired stale articles.
- Defined Paychex Assistant's knowledge-management model: inclusion criteria, taxonomy, content structure, and success metrics. In its first rollout, usage tripled, questions resolved without a rep rose from 55% to 75%, and case volume fell 6%.
- Co-led the contact phrases initiative, replacing "call a rep" language with self-serve and chat alternatives across hundreds of touchpoints. Reduced cost-to-serve 66% where the alternative was chat, and 100% where the alternative was self-service.

UX Design Operations Specialist · UX Content Designer — 2019 – 2021

- Burned down a 6-month content backlog in 2 months by reorganizing the work and cutting low-value requests.
- Owned user interface content and supporting documentation for the PPP Loan Forgiveness Estimator. Enabled 500K small businesses to secure $65B in funding.

Xerox — 2008 – 2018

Six roles, most recently Corporate Communications Manager

- Led user experience and product management for two Fortune 500 employee platforms. Directed designers and writers, defined structure and governance, and cut $125K a year in overhead.
- Defined the information architecture and metadata standards for the SharePoint-based knowledge repository used by 140,000 employees worldwide. Created a wiki and training videos to scale adoption.
- Owned and ran change management for the Xerox and Conduent separation: 140,000 employees across 180 countries.
- Grew Yammer, Xerox's internal social network, from 2,800 to 25,000 employees.
- Managed a $1M budget for Xerox's 2015 Leadership Meeting, a three-day event for 200 executives.